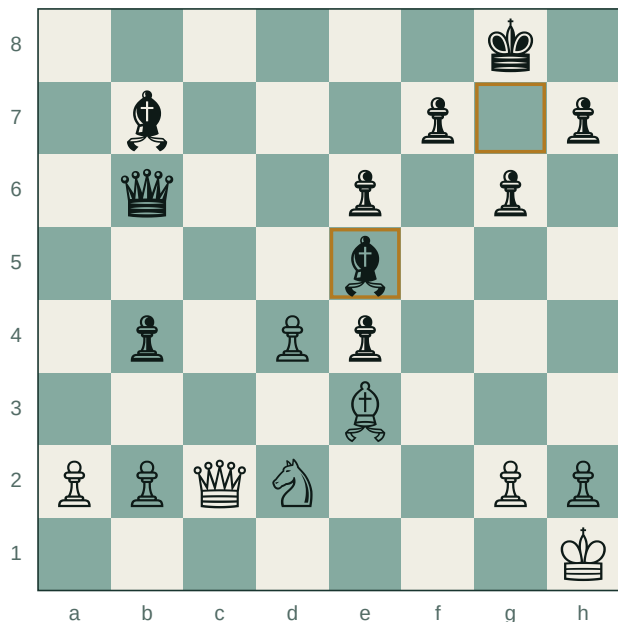


Intermediate moves: White, move 27

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 26...Bxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27. Nc4 Qb5 28. dxe5 Bd5 29. b3

27.Nc4 The knight moves from d2 to c4. From c4 it attacks queen on b6 and bishop on e5. Recorded reply: **27...Qb5**.

28.dxe5 The pawn captures the bishop on e5. Recorded reply: **28...Bd5**.

29.b3 The pawn moves from b2 to b3.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on b6 and bishop on e5. Check for tactical protection.